their Aravidu lineage and says the family is projecting Krishna as the principal heir and family spokesperson.

Krishna is a devout and seemingly humble man. He says they are Kshtriyas Rajputs. His *isht devata*, or personal deity, is Virupaksha, and *kula devata*, or family deity, is Tirupati Balaji. He says he is merely a subject of Virupaksha, the king of kings, and follows his every command. Krishna also has a guru and vouches for his supernatural powers, such as of mind reading, curing ailments and astrological predictions.

Anegundi seems like the sort of village that any aspiring adolescent would want to escape. But it's different for Krishna. To the locals, he still exudes the essence of a raya (i.e., raja). They give him respect, status and privilege of the kind that would have been impossible in the US, where he was just another brown man with an accent. Here he presides over festivals, temple ceremonies, a *rathotsav* (in which the local deity is taken around the village in a chariot). He feels the weight and burden of his ancestry and struggles to find his own way of embracing it. He seems stoic about it too, content to play the part of 'royalty' that fate has ordained for him.

At a festival in April, mimicking old custom, he crowns the Virupaksha temple priest using a crown from Vijayanagar days. After major festivals, villagers come to pay respects, including Muslims, about 10–15 per cent of the population. Inside a glass enclosure at his home are swords and daggers; the villagers pay homage to these during Dussehra, an echo of the martial substrate of that festival in Vijayanagar. I watch as three elderly housemaids, before taking leave, touch Krishna's feet with their foreheads. He stands, his hands raised in a gesture of blessing.

He is not currently interested in political office but doesn't rule it out. All political parties are the same, he fumes, full of corrupt politicians out to make money. If good people don't enter politics, bad people will rule. In the preceding two generations, two of his relatives were MLAs in the Karnataka Assembly. His father contested and lost on a BJP ticket in the early 1990s.

For now, Krishna is happy running Anegundi Foundation, an environmental NGO focused on local community projects and keeping Hampi clean. He speaks passionately about raising awareness of plastic avoidance, waste segregation and recycling, renewable energy, and conservation. He is also involved with heritage restoration projects, but